

Digvesh Rathi (in pic) idolises Sunil Narine. So, his strong start in IPL 2025 — nine wickets at an economy of 7.43 — shouldn't come as a surprise.

Rathi bowls quick googlies and leg-spin, hiding his grip till the final moment — almost Narine-like. His fast, straight-arm action makes it tough for batters to read him off the hand. The result? Deception through dip, speed, and length. (See IPL figures — Graph 1) He's already been added to the ever-growing club of IPL mystery spinners — a group led by Narine, Ajantha Mendis, and Varun Chakaravathy.

The Carrom Ball Catalyst

Mendis pioneered the 'mystery spin' in limited-overs cricket — and the IPL — when he dismantled batting line-ups in 2008 with his carrom ball, flicked like a striker on a carrom board. It could skid on or turn away from right-handers.

That very weapon inspired Narine to develop his own repertoire. By the time Narine debuted in the IPL in 2012, he was unreadable — claiming 24 wickets at an astonishing

economy of 5.47. His bag of tricks included the carrom ball, knuckle ball, doosra, off-break, and arm ball. India spin legend Harbhajan Singh puts it simply: "They're finger spinners who bowl with the wrist — like me or (Ravindra) Jadeja — but they don't spin the ball as much. Their hands work like playing carrom; that's the mystery — the action."

Unlike conventional spinners who use flight and turn, mystery spinners operate differently. Traditional spin uses an upright seam with revolutions. Mystery spin comes with a scrambled seam, hiding the ball's behaviour till late.

Flatter, Faster, Trickier

Narine and Chakaravathy both come from tennis-ball cricket, where bowlers use angles more than turn. The trajectory is flat. The speed, quicker than traditional spin.

"They learned that grip with the tennis ball. Now they're using it with the leather ball — and it's working. Batters just aren't used to that kind of wrist work," Harbhajan explains.

Their balls don't turn much. Data shows (wherever available) Narine's deliveries deviate just 1.27 degrees on average. (See Chahal vs Narine comparison graph — Graph 2). In contrast, Yuzvendra Chahal — more

conventional — sees deviations of up to 3.44 degrees.

Overspin and Dip: The Chakaravathy Switch

Chakaravathy had a breakout run with Kolkata Knight Riders in 2020 and 2021 — 35 wickets at under 7 runs per over — earning him a T20I debut.

But international success proved elusive. (See Varun's variations — Graph 3)

The turnaround came when he shifted from sidespin to overspin. The change gave him more dip and bounce instead of relying on turn. That tweak reignited his IPL form, earned him a national recall, and saw him play a key role in India's Champions Trophy win earlier this year.

Why They Work in T20s

After a poor 2011 season, Kolkata Knight Riders wanted a strike bowler who was also economical. It bought Narine in the next auction — and he delivered both.

His variations made him a wicket-taker. His speed and back-of-length bowling made him hard to hit. He rarely bowled full. Most deliveries were either a good length or shorter. At nearly 93 km/h, batters couldn't line him up.

IPL career figures

Player	Balls Bowled	Wickets	Best figures	Avg	Econ	SR
Ajantha Mendis	240	8	2/19	35.63	7.13	30.00
Sunil Narine	4,202	187	5/19	25.27	6.75	22.47
Varun Chakaravarathy	1,750	93	5/20	23.33	7.44	18.82
Digvesh Rathi	168	9	2/30	23.11	7.43	18.67